

PROCESSING

Snapped and scanned, but satisfied you are not? Here's how you add that touch of class to them!



Reducing red-eye effect

Eye pupils dilate in the dark, thus reflecting the flash light in the eye's blood vessels. This gives the person a 'red eye'. Hence, avoid photographing in the dark. If it's absolutely necessary, use a camera with red-eye reduction feature.

Tell the subject do not look directly into the lens. If possible, use a removable flash that is placed at some distance from the camera. You may also use photo management software such as Photoshop album, Picasa, ULead Photo Explorer, JASC to remove red eye.

Cropping

Cropping is used to edit unwanted portions of a photograph. Maintain the aspect ratio for prints when cropping using software. For example, if you need a 5 x 7 print, you will need to crop

the image precisely to that size. Open Photoshop and press **[Ctrl] + [R]** to enable rulers. Right-click on the ruler, and select Inches to change the ruler unit. Now, drag the horizontal guideline to 5 inches, and position the vertical guideline at 7 inches. Press **[C]** to switch to the Crop tool, and drag a rectangle of 5 by 7 inches. Move it to a suitable position, and double-click to crop; trying unusual shapes may be a good idea. For example, heart for a couple's photo. Cropping comes handy while correcting horizon lines or straightening your photos.

Automated features

Improve the quality of your photographs by using the automated functions in Photoshop. Go to **Image > Adjustments > Auto Levels** and then apply Auto Contrast and

Auto Color. Finally, sharpen them via **Filter > Sharpen > Sharpen**.

Sharpening

You can sharpen any image using Photoshop's Unsharp Mask filter (**Filter > Sharpen > 'Unsharp Mask...'**). This compensates for the blurring caused by the low-pass filter



Use Photoshop's Unsharp Mask filter to sharpen your images

that is found in almost all digital cameras to improve image quality. Apply it before the image is re-sized, or resampled, but after other corrections have been done. Its ideal settings would be a radius value of 0.3 to 0.5, threshold value of 0 to 2 and amount between 200 to 500 per cent.

For compensating the blurring done by output process, it should be sharpened after resize/ resample. Generally, finer the print, the lower will be the radius. For example, you will need a radius of 1.0 to 1.5 for photos that are printed on premium inkjet photo paper.

Wipe off dust and scratches

Make use of dust and scratch removal software to get clean scans. One such plug-in is Kodak's Digital ICE (www.asf.com). Apply the noise filter to the photo in Photoshop by going to **Filter > Noise > 'Dust and Scratches...'**. Next, despeckle the image by going to **Filter > Noise > Despeckle**.

You may also use the Clone Stamp Tool to clone a cleaner area to the dusty one. To use this Photoshop tool, press **[C]** and click on an area that resembles your target area, while holding down **[Alt]**. After defining the source, release **[Alt]** and paint in the normal way. Do remember to zoom in and keep the brush size smaller for better results.

Creating panoramas

The latest version of Photoshop CS comes with Photomerge—a feature that allows you to create panoramas in just a few clicks. The best part is that you don't even need to fix your camera on a tripod while taking images, as Photoshop adjusts the level automatically. Open Photoshop CS and click on **File > Automate > Photomerge**. Click on Use Files and use the browse button to locate all the images that want to use for creating the panorama. Make sure that the 'Attempt to Automatically Arrange Source Images' check box is checked, and click OK. A dialog box with